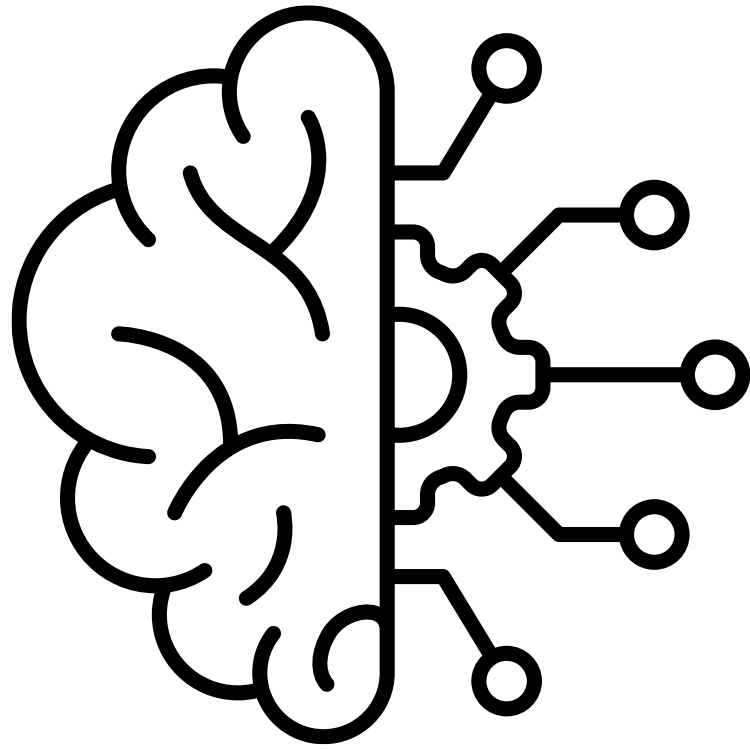




Building AI Agents for the Humanities

Session 1: Introduction to the Course

Yadira Lizama Mué, PhD

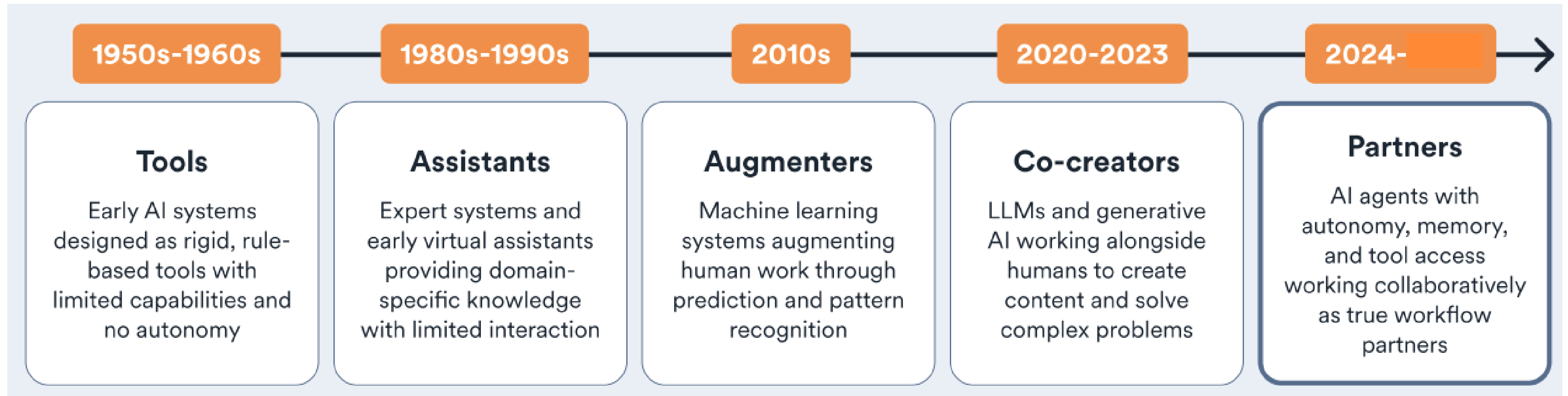
Postdoctoral Fellow, Western University
Assistant Professor of Digital Humanities





Let's Connect

Human – AI Collaboration



Beyond Chatbots: The Evolution to True Agents, Hubspot Media, 2025

What is an AI Agent?

- A system that can **reason, plan, and take actions on its own** based on the information it is given.
- It can manage **workflows**, has language generation capabilities, uses external **tools**, and **adapts** as things change.

Chatbot vs. AI Agent: Same Request, Different Outcomes

CHATBOT

Provides Information Only

“Find my best-performing blog posts from last quarter and draft social media updates for each”

Here's how you can do that:

1. Go to your analytics dashboard
2. Filter for last quarter's posts
3. Sort by page views/engagement
4. For each post, draft social updates
5. Include post links and hashtags

Here's an example template...

YOU MUST DO THE WORK

AI AGENT

Executes Complete Workflow

“Find my best-performing blog posts from last quarter and draft social media updates for each”

Connect to Analytics API

DB

Analyze Top Posts

Draft Social Media Posts

CMS

Schedule Posts

Social

COMPLETES ENTIRE WORKFLOW



n8n-io

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Type

to



n8n - Workflow Automation

Free and open fair-code licensed node based Workflow Automation Tool.

Verified

Sponsor

13.7k followers

Germany

https://n8n.io

@n8n_io

hello@n8n.io

README.md

Hi there, this is n8n 🙌

n8n is the company behind n8n, the product. We're building a workflow automation platform that gives technical teams the flexibility of code with the speed of no-code. With 400+ integrations, native AI capabilities, and a [fair-code license](#), n8n lets you build powerful automation while maintaining full control over your data and deployments.

- Check out [our main project here](#).
- Interested in working at n8n? See our [open positions](#).
- Learn more how to [self-host n8n in our docs](#).
- Not interested in hosting n8n yourself? We also offer [n8n cloud](#) for a monthly fee.
- Both our team and our users have been building a [workflow template library](#) to help others easily get started with n8n automation.

localhost:5678/workflow/xWy6QJSTBEUHzo5X

n8n

+

AI agent chat

+ Add tag

Inactive

Share

Saved

...

Star 51,309

<https://github.com/n8n-io>

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AI agents and workflows you can see and control

Get started for free

Talk to sales

Build visually, go deep with code, connect to anything. Every step of your agents' reasoning, traceable on the canvas. Deploy on your infrastructure or ours.

The world's most popular workflow automation platform for technical teams including

Microsoft

wayfair

onfleet

vodafone

<https://n8n.io/>

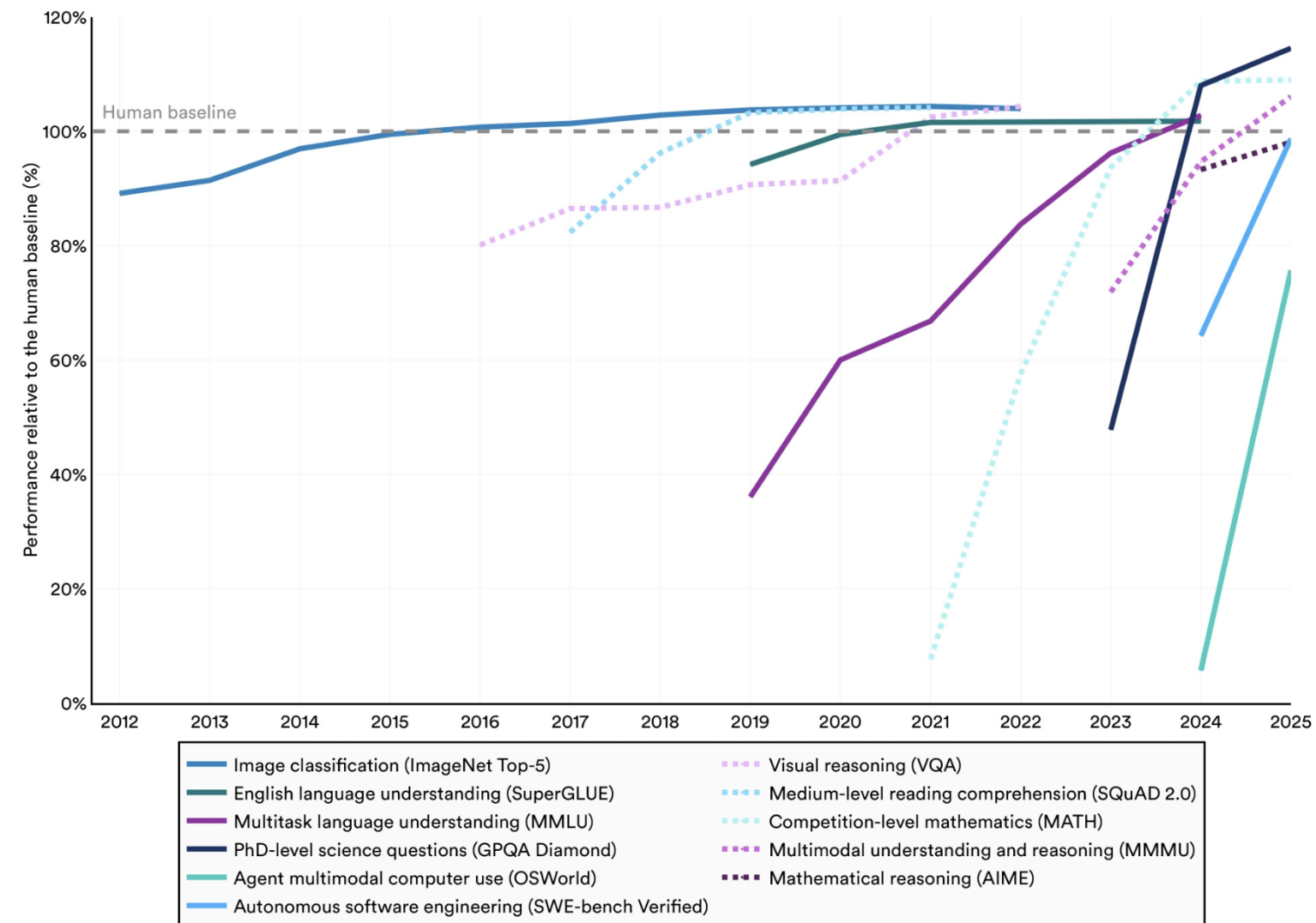
Course Outline

DAY 1	DAY 2	DAY 3	DAY 4	DAY 5
Foundations of AI Agents & Agentic AI Quick Start with N8N	Agents from Concept to Prototype. Single and Multi-agent Systems. Agents Orchestration. Building Agents to support research in the Humanities.	Large Language Models (LLMs) - Retrieval Augmented Generation (RAG) Agents.	Vision-Language Models (VLMs) in Agentic AI Large Audio Language Models. Expanding interpretive and creative possibilities.	Collaborative prototyping in the Project Studio. Peer feedback, reflections on current and future applications of AI in the humanities.

Intelligence is not what you know; it's what you do when you don't know

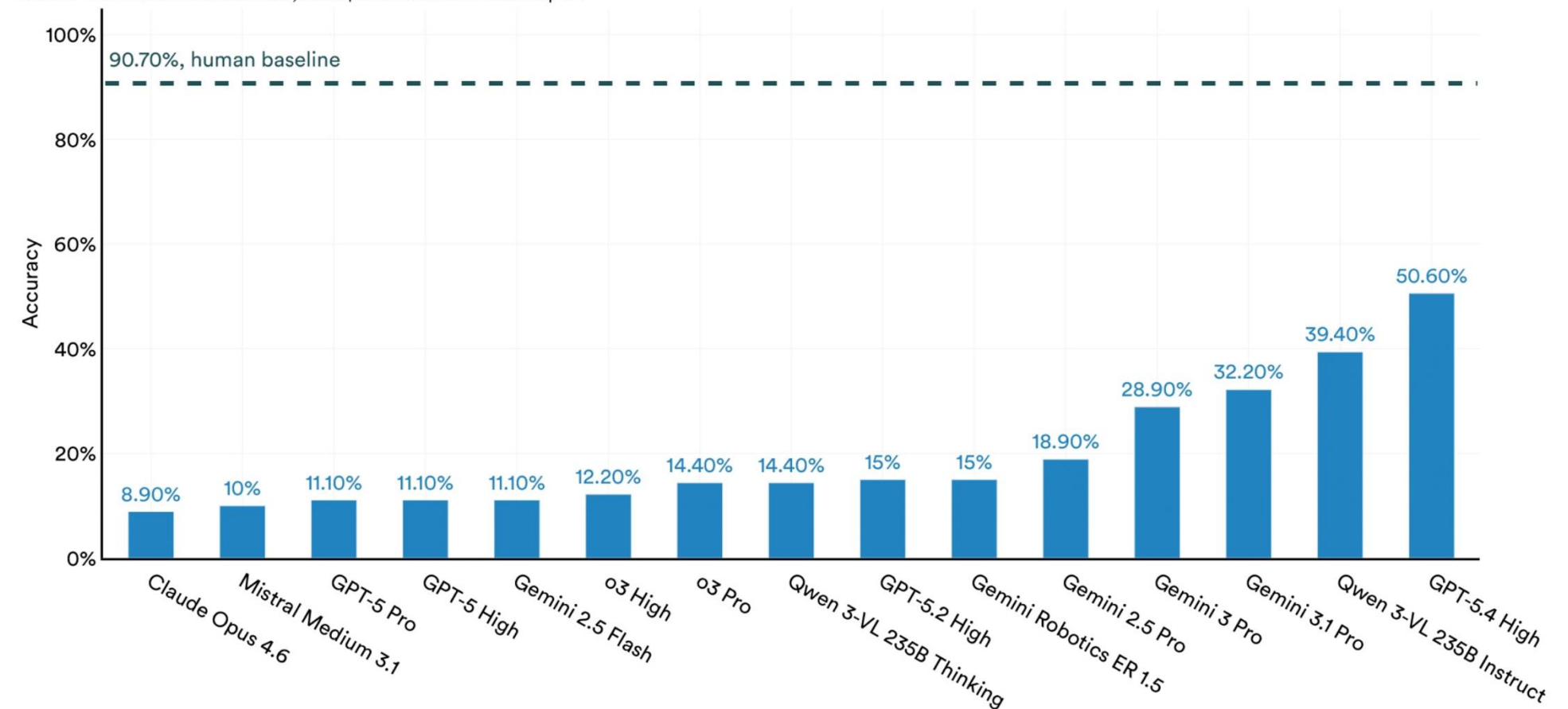
Select AI Index technical performance benchmarks vs. human performance

Source: AI Index, 2026 | Chart: 2026 AI Index report



ClockBench: accuracy

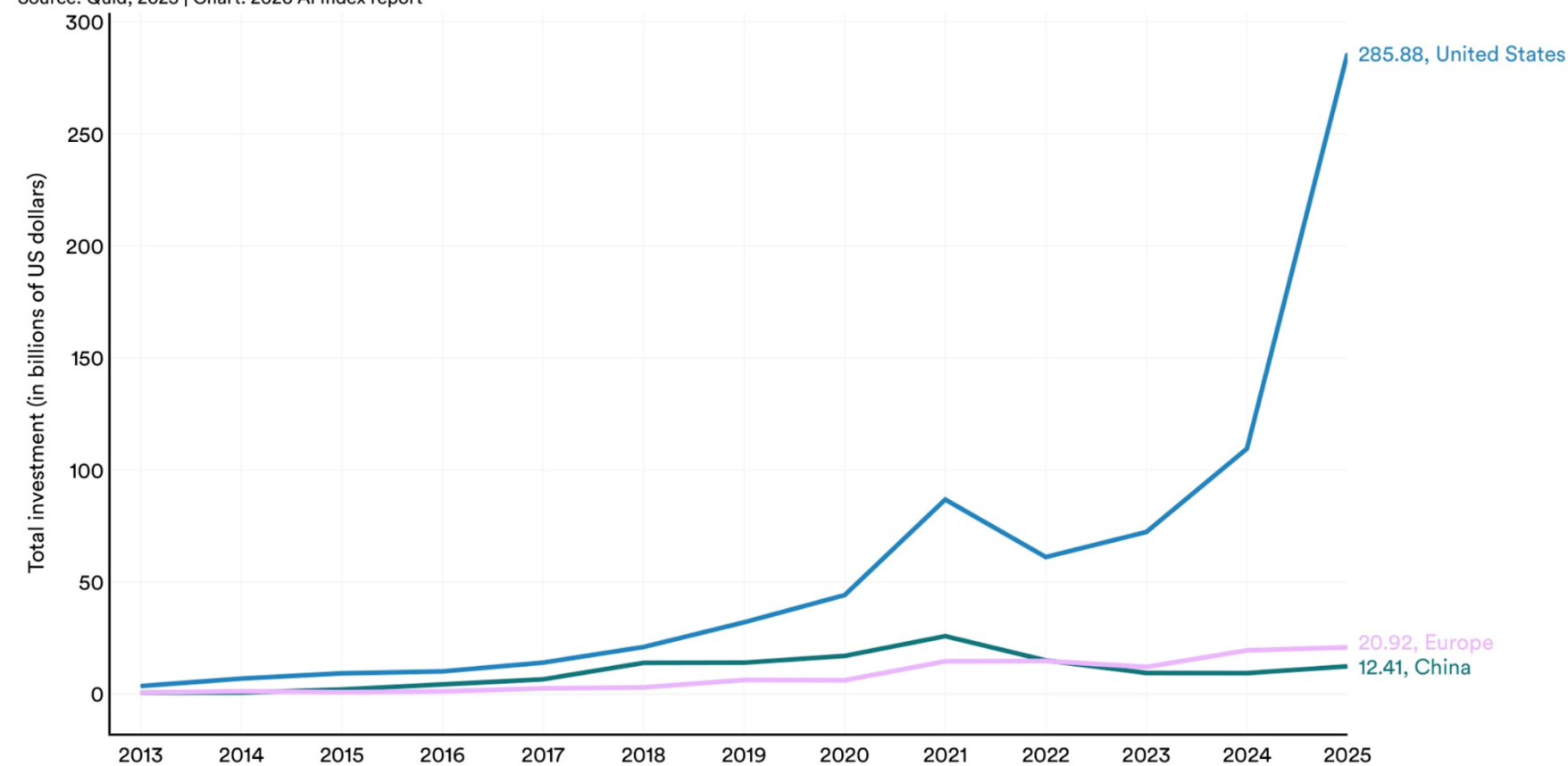
Source: ClockBench Leaderboard, 2026 | Chart: 2026 AI Index report



AI literacy is no longer optional

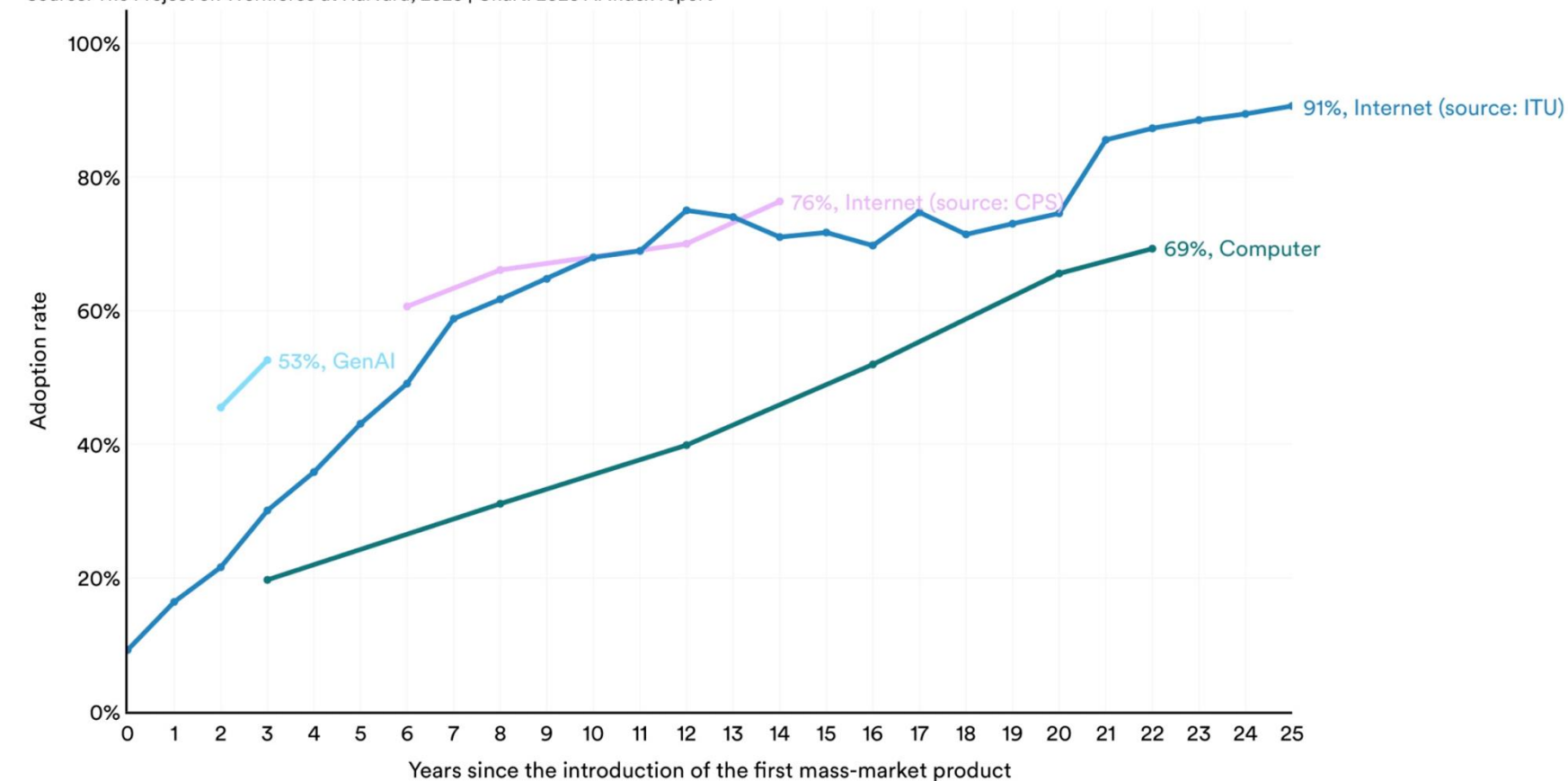
Global private investment in AI by geographic area, 2013–25

Source: Quid, 2025 | Chart: 2026 AI Index report



Speed of AI adoption by technology

Source: The Project on Workforce at Harvard, 2025 | Chart: 2026 AI Index report



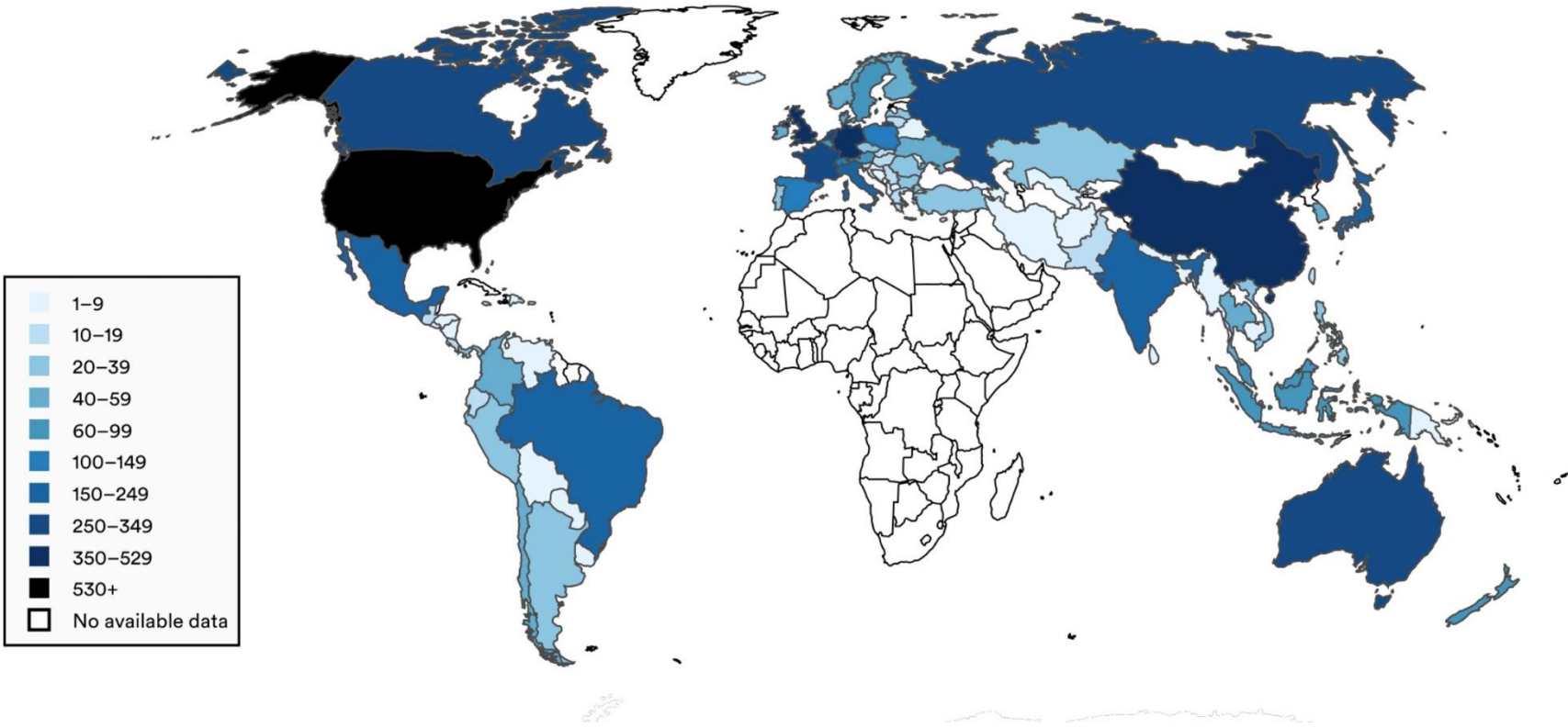
**Frictionless Design is not
Human-Centered Design**

**AI, like any other disruptive technology,
requires strategic alignment, AI
governance, and sustained training**

There is no “AI for Good” without Sustainable AI

Global distribution of data centers, 2025

Source: Cloudscene, 2025 | Chart: 2026 AI Index report



Business

Supersized data centres are coming to Canada. One province is at the epicentre

So far, Canada has 5 hyperscale data centres. Another 96 are in development.



[Kyle Bakx](#), [Nora Young](#), [Rukhsar Ali](#) · CBC News ·

Posted: Jun 04, 2026 4:00 AM EDT | Last Updated: June 4



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Estimated 8 minutes



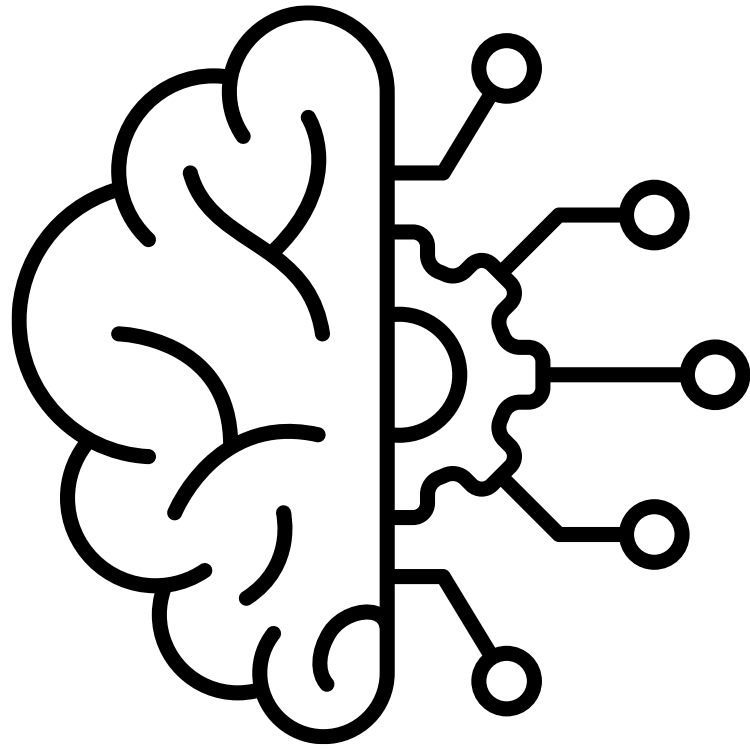
**The humanities are essential to
AI research and development**

**Would you
like to add
any?**

1. Intelligence is not what you know; it's what you do when you don't know.
2. AI literacy is no longer optional
3. Frictionless Design is not Human-Centred Design
4. AI, like any other disruptive technology, requires strategic alignment, AI governance, and sustained training
5. There is no "AI for Good" without Sustainable AI.
6. The humanities are essential to AI research and development

Learning Commitments

- Collaborate generously
- Value interdisciplinarity
- Uncertainty is part of the process
- Respect the room
- Experiment and iterate



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